



SAFE

Washing hands thoroughly and rinsing fresh produce reduce bacteria and dirt that can cause illness. Keeping the salad refrigerated below 40°F slows harmful bacterial growth. These steps follow good food safety practices to prevent foodborne illness.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



NOT SAFE

Cooked, protein-rich foods like chicken salad can grow harmful bacteria very quickly when left out above 40°F for more than 2 hours. At 85°F, bacteria multiply fast, making the salad unsafe to eat and risking foodborne illness.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



IT DEPENDS

Green beans are low-acid vegetables and typically require pressure canning to destroy harmful bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Adding lemon juice raises acidity but may not be enough to safely process green beans in a boiling water canner. Safety depends on the exact pH and following tested guidelines for acidity and processing time.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



SAFE

Because peaches are acidic fruits, they can be safely canned using a boiling water canner if you follow a tested recipe exactly. Adding lemon juice maintains the necessary acidity to prevent harmful bacteria growth. Processing the jars for the right time at boiling temperatures destroys yeasts, molds, and bacteria that can spoil the fruit or cause illness.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



NOT SAFE

Using old or damaged lids can prevent jars from sealing properly, allowing air and bacteria inside. Not washing jars and lids risks contamination. Processing for less time than recommended may leave harmful microorganisms alive. These mistakes can cause spoilage or serious foodborne illness, so the canned fruit is unsafe to eat.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



IT DEPENDS

Blueberries are acidic fruits, but the acid level can vary. Generally, boiling water canning is safe for blueberries without added acid, but some recipes recommend adding lemon juice to ensure proper acidity especially if the blueberries are less ripe or grown in low-acid conditions. Safety depends on following a tested recipe that addresses acid levels and processing times.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



SAFE

Following a tested recipe ensures your salsa is acidic enough to prevent the growth of harmful bacteria like botulism. Using 5% vinegar and processing properly in a boiling water canner kills bacteria and seals the jars safely. These exact steps are critical for safe salsa canning.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



NOT SAFE

Tomatoes need added acid-like lemon juice or citric acid-when canned in a boiling water bath because their natural acidity isn't always enough to kill botulism spores. Skipping this step or underprocessing can allow dangerous bacteria to survive.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products



IT DEPENDS

Adding fresh garlic before canning lowers the salsa's acidity, which can let botulism bacteria grow unless the recipe and processing method are specifically tested. Also, thickening before canning can cause unsafe heat penetration. You should only add such ingredients if the recipe is lab-tested to be safe.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



SAFE

Low acid foods like green beans can only be safely canned using a pressure canner because it reaches 240°F, enough to kill dangerous bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Following tested recipes and processing times ensures safety. If the jars sealed properly and the canner cooled down naturally, the food is safe to store and eat.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



NOT SAFE

Boiling water bath canners don't reach the high temperature needed to destroy botulism spores in low acid foods like meat. Over-packed jars heat unevenly, and skipping the venting step traps cold air which prevents proper heating. This risks deadly botulism.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



IT DEPENDS

Low acid cooked vegetables need pressure canning to be safe for shelf storage because the heat kills botulism spores. However, if you freeze them correctly instead, freezing keeps bacteria from growing, making the food safe without canning. So safety depends on the preservation method chosen.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home



SAFE

This is safe because the vinegar acidity level is high enough to prevent harmful bacteria. Using a tested recipe ensures the right balance of ingredients, and refrigeration slows spoilage. Eating within a few weeks reduces risk of spoilage.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables



NOT SAFE

Using homemade vinegar of unknown acidity and diluting the vinegar makes the pickle low acid. Without enough acid or proper heat processing, harmful bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum* can grow, causing serious illness.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs



IT DEPENDS

Safety depends on whether enough acid has developed from fermentation to lower pH below 4.6, which usually takes several days. Early consumption can be unsafe because harmful bacteria might still grow if acidity is insufficient.

Source: UC David Safely fermented fruit and vegetable



SAFE

Freezer jams made with tested recipes and stored frozen promptly stay safe because the cold keeps bacteria from growing. Sugar helps preserve the fruit by lowering water activity, and the recipe acidity ensures safety. Freezer jam is not heat processed, so it must be kept frozen and used soon after opening.

Source: SP 50-763 Uncooked freezer jams



NOT SAFE

Reducing sugar too much in jam or jelly without using special low-sugar pectin can make the product unsafe. Sugar helps preserve by lowering water activity and helping gel formation. Without enough sugar or special pectin, the jelly may not set properly and can allow bacteria or mold to grow even after canning.

Source: SP 50-765 Low sugar fruit spreads



IT DEPENDS

American elderberries can be low acid, meaning safety depends on sugar amount. High sugar ratios reduce water activity to stop botulism bacteria.

Lowering sugar in this jam can make it unsafe unless you follow a tested recipe designed for low sugar. You must weigh ingredients exactly and process jars properly or safety is compromised.

Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries



SAFE

Keeping frozen foods at 0°F or colder stops bacteria growth and preserves quality. Using airtight containers prevents freezer burn and contamination. Regularly checking the freezer thermometer helps ensure safe storage conditions.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



NOT SAFE

If freezer temperature rises above 40°F for long periods, bacteria can grow even if food looks okay. Opening the freezer lets cold air out, speeding thawing. Partially thawed poultry can be unsafe to eat and should be discarded.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



IT DEPENDS

Freezing fish soon after catch preserves safety, but the timing matters. Fish that were iced immediately after bleeding pass rigor mortis slowly, which maintains better quality and safety. Fish frozen before rigor or without icing can have tough texture and lower quality. If the fish wasn't fresh or iced properly before freezing, there might be safety risks.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood



SAFE

Heating the jerky after drying to 160°F or higher kills harmful bacteria that might survive the drying process. This step ensures the jerky is safe to eat and can be stored at room temperature for 1-2 months without risk.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



NOT SAFE

Smoking fish at low temperatures like 90°F without sufficient salt or cooking doesn't kill dangerous bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Without proper heating and salting, storing smoked fish at room temperature can cause lethal food poisoning.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



IT DEPENDS

Drying low-acid fruits like apricots can be safe if you pretreat them with acid (like lemon juice) or use a tested drying method because low-acid fruits can spoil or grow bacteria. Without pretreatment, the safety depends on drying time, temperature, and handling.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables